

LIVE

Learning Space

NEWSPAPER

23rd July, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

30th WEEK



AFGHANISTAN & TALIBAN

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations



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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

23rd JULY, 2018

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Dealing with the Taliban hand

In the U.S.'s battle against the Taliban, Pakistan holds the trump card



V. SUDARSHAN

Less than a year after U.S. President Donald Trump unveiled his new Afghanistan policy, last August, it lies in tatters. It is fraught with implications for New Delhi, none of them heart-warming. Mr. Trump had made New Delhi happy when he had summed it up succinctly; he had studied the situation for eight months "from all angles" and had come up with the solution. His Afghan policy was going to be robust. As he put it, "We are not nation-building again. We are killing terrorists." He blamed Pakistan for giving safe haven to "agents of chaos" and later cut off security assistance to Taliban's greatest benefactors and backers.

Reaching out

Even six months ago, at the end of January, Mr. Trump said, "We are going to finish what we have to finish in Afghanistan." The implication was that he was going to stay the course. He had declared: "We don't want to talk with the Taliban. There may be a time, but it's going to be a long time." Now the

next thing we know, about 17 years after invading Afghanistan to rid it of the Taliban, the white flags are out, and the U.S. is setting the stage for direct talks with the very enemy it vowed to vanquish. True, we have to weigh this against previous attempts at dialogue with the Taliban which ended in failure. The problem is that this time the U.S. may want the talks to succeed, which means handing Afghanistan over to the Taliban and their chief backers, the Pakistanis, beribboned and gift-wrapped.

Taliban on the rebound

Even so, the new American move comes at a time when the Taliban ranks have swelled since the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation pulled out in 2014 and they seem to be surging ahead in many parts of the country. It comes after the U.S. stopped releasing figures for the territories or populations under Taliban control, or the numbers of their fighters. It comes at a time where the data and assessments on the strength and the combat capabilities of the Afghan military and police are no longer readily available, amidst reports of severe erosion of their fighting capabilities. It comes when the UN grimly noted – late last year – rising opium production. Citing the latest Afghanistan Opium Survey figures (released by the Afghanistan's Ministry of Counter Narcotics



and the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime) it said that opium production in Afghanistan had increased by 87% to a record level of 9,000 metric tons in 2017 compared with 2016 levels. The area under opium poppy cultivation had also increased to a record 328,000 hectares in 2017, up 63% from 201,000 hectares in 2016. It comes at a time when a strategy that relies mostly on counter-terrorism operations – the vastly reduced number of troops (less than 15,000) are mainly on security assistance and training and other hand-holding assignments – is not paying sufficient dividends. It comes after Afghan President Ashraf Ghani literally sued for peace, saying that he was prepared to recognise the Taliban – previously referred to as terrorists – as a legitimate political group, offered to release Taliban prisoners, and proposed dialogue, a suggestion that was quickly and contemptu-

ously spurned. The intervention in Afghanistan has never looked quite so ramshackle.

Pakistan's game and India

It has not resulted in many critical primary military and strategic objectives being realised, the denial of safe havens (mostly in Pakistan) to the Taliban, the reduction of their fighting capability, and to effectively dis-incentivise Pakistan's zeal and ability to nurture the Taliban. The opposite has happened. Rawalpindi correctly surmised that the longer it was able to play the game of running with the hare and hunting with the hounds, the less stomach the endlessly gullible Americans would have to continue sinking troops, money and shrinking political capital into another quagmire. It has also helped Pakistan that the American President, no stranger to U-turns, has turned spectacularly fickle so far as Afghanistan is concerned. He has more than half his term left, which leaves plenty scope for him to change his mind again.

All the same, if the talks with the Taliban proceed apace, it does not matter so much where the talks will be held or how much control the Pakistanis are able to exert over their wards during the talks. What matters is this: what the Taliban, and thus more importantly, Pakistan, are able to wrest from the negotiating table. With-

drawal of the remaining international troops will be the main aim. At the end of it, the Taliban and other Pakistani proxies, who have orchestrated a string of deadly attacks on Indian interests with a view to deter New Delhi, will have the run of what passes for a country; a nation that has not yet been built. Where would that leave New Delhi?

The American move comes when there is pressure to limit any kind of engagement with Iran, which would have been a logistical pivot for further inroads into Afghanistan. Already, with the exit of Hamid Karzai, the strategic comfort that New Delhi had in Kabul stands diminished, and by extension, the kind of intelligence operations New Delhi may have had the option to conduct with deniability. Pakistan's aim will be to reverse all the gains India has made at great cost over the years in Afghanistan. With strategic depth in Afghanistan that Pakistan has dreamt of becoming a reality, Islamabad will have more room to incubate and move around the various anti-India groupings, including those active in Kashmir, as was the case earlier, especially in Lōya Paktiā. With the prospect of the Taliban slouching towards Kabul to be born again, most of New Delhi's bets may be off.

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2 Dealing with the Taliban hand

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UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations

Effect of policies and politics of developed and developing countries on India's interests, Indian diaspora.

IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

Discuss the South-Asia Policy of US on Afghanistan and examine how peace in Afghanistan is vital for India.

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23rd July, 2018



BRIEF HISTORY OF AFGHANISTAN ISSUE



Ashraf Ghani Ahmadzai
President

- In 1978, People's Democratic Party of Afghanistan (PDPA) took power in military coup, which is known as "Saur Revolution"
- In 1979, then Soviet Union entered Afghanistan and war started between

Soviet Union led
Afghan Forces

X

Mujahidin's allegedly
supported by USA,
Pakistan



Country	Afghanistan
Capital	Kabul
Currency	Afghani

- In 1989, Soviet Forces left Afghanistan.
- In 1990s, Taliban rose to power with the support of some countries.

BRIEF HISTORY OF AFGHANISTAN ISSUE



- ✓ Subsequent to September 11, 2001 attacks in USA, NATO interfered in the affairs of Afghanistan under “**Operation Enduring Freedom**”
- ✓ The purpose of NATO intervention is to
 - **Defeat Al-Qaeda**
 - **Remove Taliban from power**
 - **To create viable democratic state.**
- ✓ NATO stayed in Afghanistan for 13 years (2001-2014), and most of the forces left in December 2014.
- ✓ Now, less than around 15,000 forces of NATO are available in Afghanistan primarily to assist Afghan forces.



**ALASKA
UNITED STATES**

UNITED STATES

AFGHANISTAN

PAKISTAN

WHY AFGHANISTAN IS NOT ABLE TO CONTROL TALIBAN?

- 1 There are allegations that Taliban has got bases in Pakistan and its activities are supported by some elements in Pakistan.
- 2 There is no coherent policy in controlling Taliban and in the discussions for peace in Afghanistan, some countries are in favour of taking Taliban on board, where as some countries are not in favour of that.
- 3 The withdrawal of troops by NATO resulted in vacuum and afghan forces are not equipped in tackling Taliban.

- 4 Taliban's power / influence goes to almost one-third / half of the country and it is getting support from rural hinterland.
- 5 There is lot of corruption in the Government sector in Afghanistan. It is also one reason for Taliban to get support.
- 6 The Governance structure in Afghanistan is quite weak and army is demoralized a lot.





TRUMP'S SOUTH-ASIA POLICY

- 1** The US President, about a year ago, stated that the US troops would stay in Afghanistan for an open ended period of time.
- 2** He also stated that the shift is from time-based approach to one based on conditions.
- 3** America's strategic partnership with India will deepen in South Asia and Indo-Pacific.
- 4** India must make more financial contribution for the stability of Afghanistan.
- 5** Military in Afghanistan will be given more operational autonomy to tackle terrorists and commanders will be given authority to attack, whenever they chose to.
- 6** USA would no longer tolerate Pakistan's policy of harbouring terrorists.

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SEE THE PRESENT DAY REALITY!



1 Pakistan is giving shelter to the extremist elements.

2 They are crossing the border to reach Afghanistan.

3 Islamic State (IS) is extending its tentacles seeing the vacuum.

4 Taliban is occupying almost one-third to half of the country.

5 NATO forces withdrew in 2014. Subsequently, the Taliban ranks have swelled.

SEE THE PRESENT DAY REALITY!



6 The combat capabilities of Afghan military and police are not up to the mark.

7 Opium production in Afghanistan increased by 87% to a record level of 9000 metric tons in 2017 compared with 2016 levels.

8 The area under opium poppy cultivation also increased to a record 3,28,000 hectares in 2017, up 63% from 2,01,000 hectares in 2016.

9 Less than 15,000 troops are mainly giving security assistance and training.





PRESENT DAY CHANGE IN STRATEGY



ASHRAF GHANI
President of Afghanistan

- 1 Ashraf Ghani said, he was prepared to recognise the Taliban as a legitimate political group.
- 2 He offered to release Taliban prisoners.
- 3 He proposed dialogue.

Whatever way you look at, the road ahead appears to be not satisfactory

WE EXPRESS OUR SINCERE THANKS FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

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Learning Space

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